

THE WALL STREET JOURNAL.

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★★★★ \$5.00

DJIA 43449.90 ▼ 267.58 0.61%

NASDAQ 20109.06 ▼ 0.3%

STOXX 600 513.66 ▼ 0.4%

10-YR. TREAS. ▲ 3/32, yield 4.384%

OIL \$70.08 ▼ \$0.63

GOLD \$2,644.40 ▼ \$7.00

EURO \$1.0493

YEN 153.50

What's News

Business & Finance

◆ **Japanese carmakers** Honda and Nissan said they were exploring a merger following a downturn in Nissan's results and struggles by both automakers in China. **A1**

◆ **The FTC required** businesses to display all fees in the total price shown to consumers when they book lodgings or live-event tickets in an effort to expose so-called junk or hidden charges. **A2**

◆ **Major U.S. stock indexes** declined, with the S&P 500, Dow industrials and Nasdaq shedding 0.4%, 0.6% and 0.3%, respectively. **B11**

◆ **GM and billionaire** developer Daniel Gilbert plan to overhaul Detroit's Renaissance Center office complex in a \$1.6 billion project that proposes to employ \$350 million in public subsidies. **B1**

◆ **Nvidia said it would** introduce a \$249 version of its Jetson computer for artificial-intelligence applications to attract more hobbyists and small companies. **B1**

◆ **Walmart took Meituan** as a partner to make the retailer's goods available on the Chinese company's app. **B2**

◆ **Sandoz said it would** pay \$275 million to settle claims from some plaintiffs in a generics drug-pricing antitrust lawsuit in the U.S. **B3**

◆ **Pfizer forecast 2025** revenue and earnings in line with market expectations, despite an expected \$1 billion hit from the redesign of U.S. federal drug benefits. **B3**

◆ **Danish brewer Carlsberg** was cleared to proceed with its takeover of Britvic after regulators in the U.K. and the EU approved the deal. **B3**

World-Wide

◆ **Congressional leaders** reached a deal to keep the government running through mid-March and provide over \$100 billion in relief to disaster victims and farmers. **A1**

◆ **Ukraine said it killed** Russian general Igor Kirillov in Moscow in a targeted attack after naming the officer as a suspect in a war-crimes investigation for allegedly ordering the use of banned chemical weapons in Ukraine. **A1**

◆ **The Biden administration** will provide a record \$15 billion low-interest loan commitment to California utility PG&E to support projects to fight the effects of climate change and improve the electrical grid. **A3**

◆ **Luigi Mangione** was indicted on new charges in the shooting death of a UnitedHealth executive, including a first-degree murder offense prosecutors said was committed to further an act of terrorism. **A3**

◆ **A San Francisco jury** found Nima Momeni guilty of second-degree murder in the fatal 2023 stabbing of Cash App founder Bob Lee. **A3**

◆ **A judge was found** culpable of misconduct for questioning the ethics of Supreme Court Justice Alito in an essay in the New York Times. **A4**

◆ **House Democrats** rejected New York Rep. Alexandria Ocasio-Cortez for a prominent leadership role in the new Congress and instead backed Gerry Connolly of Virginia. **A4**

◆ **Israel's defense minister** signaled the country is planning to keep tighter and longer-term security control over territory just across its border in Syria and in Gaza. **A8**

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An explosion in Moscow on Tuesday killed Russian Lt. Gen. Igor Kirillov, in black, head of a unit defending against biological attacks.

Ukraine Kills Russian General In Moscow Scooter Bomb Blast

By GEORGI KANTCHEV AND JAMES MARSON

Ukraine carried out one of its most audacious operations on Russian soil early Tuesday, killing the commander of the unit designed to protect Russia's troops from chemical, radiological and biological attack, by blowing up a scooter on the snowy streets of Moscow.

Lt. Gen. Igor Kirillov is the most senior commander to be killed in the heart of the Russian capital since the start of the war in Ukraine. The head of the Russian Armed Forces'

Radiological, Chemical and Biological Defense Troops, Kirillov was killed outside a residential building along with his assistant, Russian law-enforcement authorities said.

Ukrainian officials said the killing was a special operation by the Security Service of Ukraine, the country's primary domestic intelligence agency, known as the SBU.

Kyiv has sought to use targeted attacks against Russian military commanders, prominent pro-war figures and military installations far from the front to gain an edge in the nearly three-year-old war with

its giant neighbor that has left tens of thousands dead and destroyed several Ukrainian cities. Ukrainian forces have been accused of using drones to attack the Kremlin as well as planting explosive devices and using close-range gunfire to target high-profile figures in Russia.

Russian authorities classified Kirillov's killing as an act of terror. After the explosion, the deputy head of Russia's Security Council, Dmitry Medvedev, said Kyiv was trying to "prolong the war and death" and promised "inevitable retribution," state newswire

TASS reported. "Law-enforcement agencies must find the killers in Russia and everything must be done to destroy those who ordered it who are in Kyiv," Medvedev said, blaming Ukraine's military and political leadership for the attack.

A Pentagon official said the U.S. had no prior knowledge of the operation. "The United States was not aware of the operation in advance and we do not support or enable these kinds of activities," said Air Force Maj. Gen. Pat Ryder, a Pentagon spokesman.

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Housing Crisis Goes Global

Home prices and rents rise faster than incomes in world's cities

By JOSH MITCHELL

DUBLIN—When Mikey Cullen's parents were in their early 20s, they earned enough as public-sector workers to buy a house in the city. Today, Cullen is a 27-year-old high-school teacher who lives with his mother.

Cullen had been sharing a house with nine roommates, but he moved back home when he realized he couldn't afford his own place even in the cheaper parts of Dublin. Renting a one-bedroom apartment, he said, would consume most of his paycheck, and buying

something was out of the question because the median home price is eight times his annual salary.

Many Irish of his generation are in a similar bind. Fifty-nine percent of Irish adults ages 20 to 34 were living with their parents in 2022, up from 38% a decade earlier—the largest increase among major European countries, according to a report commissioned by the Irish government.

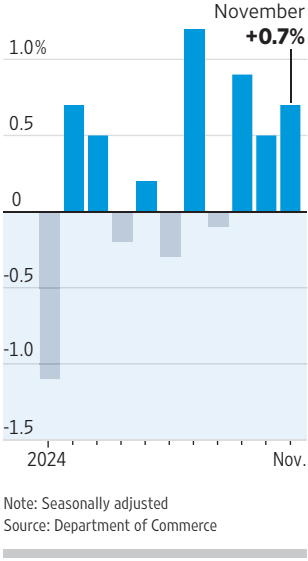
"The price in Ireland is mental," Cullen said. "Owning a home isn't feasible."

The housing affordability Please turn to page A10

Spending Stays Strong

Retail sales rose in November, extending a stretch of resilient consumer spending. **A2**

U.S. retail sales, change from a month earlier



Note: Seasonally adjusted Source: Department of Commerce

Honda, Nissan Hold Talks on Possible Deal

By PETER LANDERS

Honda and Nissan said they were exploring a merger following a downturn in Nissan's results and struggles by both automakers in China.

The discussions between two of Japan's biggest carmakers and longtime rivals highlight how China's rapid rise in the global auto market is reconfiguring the industry. Confirming a report in the Nikkei newspaper, Honda and Nissan said Wednesday they were in talks over a merger or other future collaboration. They said no final decision has been made.

The companies have grown closer this year and previously announced plans to work together on electrification tech-

nologies, seeking to share development costs.

Both are struggling in China, the world's largest auto market, after being caught flat-footed by that country's rapid shift to electric vehicles and plug-in hybrid vehicles. Nissan has also posted weaker results in the U.S.

A combination would allow Honda and Nissan to seek synergies in purchasing and technology development, but it would also present challenges for two companies with different cultures and partly overlapping vehicle lineups.

Last month, Nissan announced restructuring plans that include cutting 9,000 jobs globally and reducing its global production capacity by Please turn to page A6

What Happens When Architects Make Gingerbread Houses

Firm's 90-minute competition has pros building masterpieces and 'glorious messes'

By LAUREN WEBER

When you ask architects and designers to build gingerbread houses, you'll probably end up with at least one homage to Brutalism.

Every year, the Manhattan design studio founded by architect David Rockwell hosts a gingerbread house contest. Wine flows, candy abounds, and around 25 teams crowd around two long tables lined with cardboard boxes. Each box contains a premade gingerbread house, a bag of icing and an assortment of confections including Necco wafers, Smarties and M&Ms.

This year, the final creations—the results of 90 minutes of intensely focused ef-

fort—including two carousels (one atop a spinning base), a tableau from the Paris Olympics, a ski village, and yes, a Brutalist tower dubbed one of the ugliest university buildings in America.

Rockwell Group has designed structures ranging from the Miami Dolphins' training center to playgrounds to sets for the Oscars, along with luxury hotels, high-end restaurants and hospitals. Rockwell, 68, who mingled among teams as they finished their gingerbread inventions, launched the contest in 2016, inspired by activities offered at the downtown art school his children attended.

"I think you have to take Please turn to page A12

Suit Shows Glide Path To Top Schools for Rich

By DOUGLAS BELKIN

A lawsuit alleging universities colluded to determine students' financial-aid packages provides a glimpse into the ways top schools assess children of privilege differently from the rest of the applicant pool.

At Georgetown University, a former president selected students for a special admission list by consulting their parents' donation history, not their transcript, according to the suit. At Massachusetts Institute of Technology, a board member got the school to admit two applicants who were children of a wealthy former business colleague, the suit alleges. And at Notre Dame, an enrollment official in charge of a special applicant list wrote to others, "Sure hope the wealthy next year raise a

few more smart kids!," according to the suit.

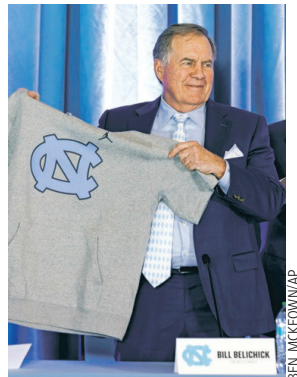
The motion, filed Tuesday in Illinois federal court, is the latest salvo in a lawsuit that began in January 2022. The plaintiffs, former students, initially accused more than a dozen elite universities with price fixing. Twelve schools have since settled.

The motion on Tuesday seeks class-action status for the case against the remaining five schools: MIT, Notre Dame, University of Pennsylvania, Georgetown and Cornell University.

For families embroiled in the college application process and facing ever steeper odds to win entry to elite schools, the records feed suspicions that colleges have different standards for children of means.

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INSIDE



SPORTS

How Belichick wound up at UNC, and what it says about college football. **A14**

BUSINESS & FINANCE

Hedge funds are placing their AI bets on utility stocks, as power demand grows. **B1**